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Ungrounded

Lost in the emotions of Danni's difficult victory over Amanda was the fact that it lined her up for a semi-final showdown with Megan Fox. Fox's style was no secret. Submissions, submissions, submissions. Megan was a top-notch grappler all the way. Her tools were a stalwart defense, and an insatiable desire to take the action to the canvas. If she gets her hands on you, trouble is bound to follow. Danni's job was to make sure that didn't happen.

Did she succeed?

Hell, no.

Three times. Three times over the course of three rounds, Fox had Danni right where she wanted her. It's strange to even say that because a submission expert of Megan's caliber usually needs only one takedown to get the win. Two gets it done for sure, and three would be overkill.

Want to hear something even stranger? Even three wasn't enough to beat Danni.

How did it all happen? Well, the takedowns I can explain easily enough. It all came down to Megan's level of commitment. Danni did everything she was supposed to do. Striking from distance, and punishing her younger foe whenever she tried to come inside. But Fox's defensive skills let her stay patient as she felt her way around things. Then she showed she was willing to take some of that punishment in order to get what she wanted. As the timer ticked into the final minute of the first, Megan feinted forward, drawing out Danni's jab. Fox avoided the blow, then tried to follow Danni's hand as she drew it back to guard. Danni saw it, understood what was happening and quickly launched the right hand. The punch was perfect, catching Fox flush as she came forward... but she kept coming. Danni threw the left and scored again. Fox pressed forward, undaunted. Next thing you knew, Megan had the grip she wanted.

There was an interesting quirk to Fox's plan... as much as she wanted to be in close, it was not a safe place for her to be. Danni was bigger and stronger, and she would out-muscle Megan if they got into a grappling contest. But Fox knew that going in, so her strategy called for zero wasted time from first touch to takedown. Get the grip, position the feet, hip in and go. She used her body to lever Danni off the mat, then turned and threw her down like a sack of dirt. The whole move took less than two seconds. Such was the skill of Megan Fox.

Danni hit the mat hard... with the kind of reverberating thump that makes the whole audience cringe. That hit is what makes the hip throw so effective. The impact is not only painful but very disorienting. By the time you get done thinking *what the fuck just happened*, your opponent is on top of you... and probably trying to break your arm off.

How do you handle it? The solution was a simple and logical trade-off. Forget the fall. No matter how hard Danni hit the canvas, that pain would be nothing compared to what Megan would do next. So the smart move was to forget the fall and focus on defending herself from what would come after. But... how? How do

you convince your brain to ignore the fact that you're flying through the air and about to go splat? How do you push aside the natural instinct to cushion the impact?

The answer is practice, and Danni had plenty of it. She knew the logic, and she had the experience to know what she had to do. She took the hit full-force, then fought through that initial shock and focused on being ready. On full alert, with her eyes on Fox the whole time.

But riding out the fall is only half the battle. Fox was still in control and her options were almost limitless. The arm was one option, but leg holds, chokes, neck cranks... there were a lot of ways to make an opponent scream out her surrender, and Megan Fox knew all of them. So, Danni still had a lot to worry about. Ground defense isn't about preventing a specific move. It's about taking away the options. It's about having the presence of mind - when the world is spinning and the action is moving at a million miles an hour - to not leave yourself exposed. Get your arms in tight. Pull your legs up. Tuck your head in. Cover your torso. Give her nothing to grab and no way to get inside. And don't stop moving. Because all this tucking and covering is good, but your opponent is going to pull it all back apart if you just lay there like a turtle.

It sounds easy when it's laid out that way, but it's not. Just ask the endless list of broken opponents Fox has left in her wake. But Danni... she made it look as natural as breathing. The second she landed, she balled herself in. So fast and so tight that Fox actually lost a few precious seconds to indecision... scanning for a weakness to exploit where Danni had left her none. In the end, she decided to straight at her opponent. To try and use her considerable ground skills to out-maneuver the RSI team leader. It was a bad decision. Megan reached out to grab and Danni immediately latched onto her hand and pulled the younger brunette across her body. A split-second later, she had her other arm behind Fox's back. Then she hugged her in tight - pressing their bodies together and leaving Megan with no room to operate. Fox tried to work her other arm out of the embrace. Danni felt it and - realizing her opponent was thinking offense instead of worrying about protecting herself - she saw her opportunity. Almost instantly she pressed her outside foot against the canvas and rolled them both over.

Five seconds after the takedown, Danni was on top. A second after that, she was firmly mounted on Megan's chest and pounding away - using her left hand for control while hammering her opponent's face with the right. One... two... three solid punches landed before Fox managed to get hold of Danni's hand. Harris tried the left, but Megan squirmed and bucked and hand grappled and eventually got Danni in a hug of her own. Danni was too firmly mounted to throw but Fox had everything too tangled up for her to continue her attacks. Stalemate... which was exactly what Danni wanted. With the action at a standstill, referee Lena Gercke was forced to step in and get both fighters back on their feet... where Danni had a decided advantage.

As Gercke prepared to restart the battle, Danni's expression was all business. Like the whole sequence had been just another day at the office. Fox, meanwhile, had a dazed, *what the hell just happened to me?* look on her face.

I felt for her because what happened simply should not have. Danni is not helpless on the ground. She is a master at defending herself and tangling her opponent into a draw... forcing the ref to step in. But the way

she'd so quickly turned this one back on Megan... not just defending but immediately going on the attack? No amount of scouting could have prepared Fox for that.

Where did it come from? I suspected the answer was a combination of things. Some recipe of foreknowledge, tactics and practice. A dash of Steph, who had no doubt given Danni some ideas on how to handle Fox's extremely aggressive ground game. A healthy helping of Amanda, who was skilled enough at grappling on the canvas to make her sparring partner work for it. A teaspoon of Tiz would explain that sharp *screw you zing* left in Megan's mouth by the way Danni had shown so little respect for her ground proficiency. But the main ingredient had to be Emma. Taking the fight to Megan on Fox's terms was as surprising as it gets, and surprising is Em's specialty.

The action had barely restarted when the clacker sounded the ten-second warning. Danni pushed forward - looking to launch a final flurry - but Fox was content to retreat out of range and let the clock run out.

Not a lot of damage done by either fighter, but I felt Danni had put round one firmly on her side of the ledger by maintaining control nearly the entire time. And if that wasn't enough, then the slick reversal of Fox's ground attack should certainly have swayed the judges in her direction.

Neither corner seemed particularly flustered during the break. Steph - who was available because she was not in action again until the following day - was as stoic as ever. Danni was equally unemotional. So far, she had handled everything Fox had put in front of her with her customary confidence and poise. Nothing to worry about, but nothing to get excited over, either. There was still a long way to go and a lot of work to be done.

There was little for the experts to do as far as injuries went. A little swelling control for Megan, and that was about it.

Meanwhile, I'm not sure if someone in her corner put an idea in her head or if Megan was just improvising, but she came out for round two looking to put her stamp on this fight in a big way. As the two fighters slowly closed on each other, Fox suddenly quickened her step. It started as a full-on, kamikaze charge, but she pulled up just as she got in range. Her guard was high and tight, and she was carefully studying Danni's reaction as she searched for an opening.

And Danni... well, even she would later admit that she got caught napping. Megan's quick sprint startled her, and her response was more instinctive than reasoned. She got her guard up and her feet set, but she was a split-second too slow realizing what Megan was really up to. Not necessarily a fatal mistake, but one that immediately put her at a disadvantage. Like being slow out of the blocks at the start of a sprint race. Fox was on her before she could get a punch off. Megan hesitated for only a second before she found the hole she needed, then lunged inside... her shoulder slamming into Danni right around hip height. She continued to drive forward. *Running the shot* it's called. Trying to go straight through Danni, and run her backward until she fell. The key to making it work is to wrap up both legs on the initial grab. That was Danni's last hope. To get her legs back and out of reach. But that lost second from the start cost her, and Fox got the wrap before she could get clear. That left Danni without a leg to stand on. Literally.

She went down hard on her back, and Megan landed right on top of her. No scrambling around or jockeying for position this time. The takedown was clean and Fox was already where she wanted to be. She pounded a few punches to keep Danni on the defensive, then quickly went after Danni's left arm. Grab, shift, kick out... it seemed like all one move and Megan was suddenly in position to work the armbar. Danni recognized the danger and immediately put a stop to it. Reaching up with her right hand, she locked her arms together in a way that almost looked like she was trying to choke out an invisible opponent. That same tight interlocking that made a good choke so dangerously difficult to escape was now preventing Megan from pulling Danni's left arm free. Fox went to work trying to break the grip with her feet. Kicking and pushing Danni's right arm away. The technique was effective... as Danni knew it would be. Her defense wasn't going to hold. She would need to find a better way to protect herself, and she already had something in mind. As Fox methodically worked, Danni suddenly released the lock and kicked her left leg up. Before the younger fighter could take advantage, Danni locked her left wrist under her own left knee and grabbed onto her own leg. Then she brought her right leg up and locked it over her left foot to secure the whole thing. It was kind of a complicated pretzel of a defense, but it was also extremely effective. Both the grip of her hand and the bend of her knee had not only secured the arm, but had done it in a way that was no longer directly in front of Fox. Megan couldn't work to break it without giving up her position, which is exactly what Danni wanted.

Stalemate? Not exactly. Great ground fighters know when an opportunity is lost. That kind of thinking is what makes Megan so good. Moments ago, she'd been on the verge of victory, but Danni had thwarted her. True, she still had the dominant position. She could try to grind it out and break Danni's defense, but she knew her odds of success were now way down. No sense wasting time and effort. Also, with her arm out of danger for the moment, Danni was already starting to work toward escaping. Rather than getting bogged down with that sort of back and forth maneuvering, Fox knew she was better off changing tactics and maintaining her momentum.

For Danni, step one in getting loose meant getting out from under Megan's legs. Rather than fight it, Fox saw an opportunity. As soon as Danni went to work on the lower leg, Megan swung her upper leg over and behind Danni's head. Danni was quick to recognize what she was up to, but that's the thing about Fox. All of this was happening in a matter of seconds. From takedown to armbar to Danni's fast-thinking defense and now to this. Speed. Momentum. Danni was doing an excellent job, but that second she lost at the very start was still haunting her. By the time she realized Fox was trying to get behind her, the transition was done. Megan was in position, her left arm looped around Danni's neck. Her right hand coming across to grip the elbow and lock in the choke hold. Once again, then end was in sight. The submission queen was going to collect another victim.

Once again, Danni put a stop to it.

Just as Megan went to close the hold, Danni shot her left arm up into the loop. It was an awkward looking block. Actually, it looked downright stupid. Danni with her head and arm trapped. Looking like a rag doll in Megan's embrace. But it was also a hundred percent effective. The choke could not be completed with Danni's arm in the way. Simple as that.

Two big opportunities lost, yet Fox was still in complete control. But something else was happening. Something subtle but elementally important. Danni was catching up. Each time she upset what Fox had

planned, she forced the younger fighter to stop and make decisions. Fox was very quick to process such situations and take action, but it still took a little time. Little delays that chipped away at that second of advantage.

Now, with the block secured and virtually unbreakable, Danni did the smartest thing she possibly could. Nothing.

She had options. Moves to make and escapes she could work. But all of them were highly technical and very risky. Not the kind of thing you try against a seasoned expert like Fox. So she did nothing. Effectively throwing the ball back in Megan's court.

Well, no... not exactly nothing. Because Megan had options, too. A lot of options. That's what Danni focused on. Surviving. Keeping Fox at bay. Every squirm. Every slide. Every wiggle. Every slight movement Fox made was met with an equally minimal counter movement from Danni. The message was clear.

Go for it, Megan. Any move you try, I'm going to be ready to fight.

When it comes down to it, submissions are just like any other offensive attack. Success requires cooperation from the opponent. Megan was fast and skilled and she counted on being able to spot and exploit mistakes before the other fighter had a chance to correct them. Danni's passive approach was a declaration that she wasn't going to let that happen. She wasn't going to take chances and give Fox free opportunities. She was going to make her earn it.

Which left Megan with a problem. The choke attempt had been sudden, decisive and unexpected. Had it worked, the pundits would have been singing her praises over the brilliant move. But it hadn't worked, and now she was backed into something of a corner. There weren't a lot places to transition to from here. Danni's legs were out of reach. There were some body locks she could try, but those were risky and Danni knew the signs to look for. It would not be easy.

Then there was the most obvious choice. The arm. Upstretched right there in front of Megan's face. If Fox could get hold of it, she could go back to work. Try again for the armbar, or use it as leverage to progress to something else. There would be a brief second between releasing the choke and grabbing the arm where Danni would be free, but she would have to be damn fast to get the arm out of danger. Meanwhile, the risk to Megan was almost nil. Even if Danni got loose, the worst case scenario was that the fight went back to standing. Not the ideal result for Fox, but not the end of the world.

All that led to a contest of wills. Megan trying to gradually improve her position. Patiently setting the stage for her to make her move. Danni making life difficult from below. Improving her own position as she waited on her opponent.

Then the moment came, and all the statistics and scenarios went for naught. Because what Danni did blew my prediction of Megan's *worst case* right out of the water.

Megan released the choke. Danni reacted instantly, flipping onto her belly with the speed of a professional chef flipping a pancake. But Megan got hold of the arm. Mission accomplished? Not quite. Danni pushed off

the mat with her right hand and got up to her knees. Megan tried to straighten the arm just as Danni leaned back and pulled. Using her arm like the rope in a game of tug-of-war. Then she showed off that new reserve of power Steph had been talking about. Muscling Fox toward her as she unloaded the right hand.

WHAM!

The punch hit Megan square in the face - the force multiplied by the way Danni had pulled her into it. Instinct told Fox to hold onto the arm. That was her key to victory, and she couldn't let it get away.

Danni hit her again. Another skull-rattling shot. A new instinct took hold of Megan. The instinct to survive. She abandoned the arm and scrambled back awkwardly. Hands and feet churning as she tried to crab-walk out of danger.

For a second time, Danni had survived on the mat with the most lethal ground fighter in her weight class. This time, her ordeal had lasted nearly two minutes. Patience and confidence and focus had gotten her through it as she methodically countered everything Megan threw at her. It was a tremendous accomplishment that few could lay claim to. Still, getting back on her feet had to be an enormous relief.

Or, at least, it would have been. If she'd decided to stand up.

In yet another inexplicable moment, Danni chose to keep the fight on the ground. As Fox crawled away, the RSI leader went after her. Grabbing her opponent's right leg, she pulled Megan back toward her as she started to move up the younger fighter's right side. Fox kicked out with her other leg, but Danni deflected the blow - using both her arm and the captured leg to shield herself. She moved further up Megan's side as she poked at her with short jabs. Quick, darting punches, designed more to keep Fox busy than do any real damage. The distraction allowed her to gain side control. Laying across Fox and using her own body weight to press Megan into the canvas. She started jabbing with the left again, and now she was getting results. Mashing her knuckles into Megan's nose twice before Fox got her arms up to protect herself. Then came the knees. Short, angry shots that dug into Megan's side. Fox squirmed and angled and finally got the situation under control, but all she could do was tie things up the way she had earlier. Both fighters went passive, and Gercke stepped in with just under forty seconds to go in the round.

As the fighters reset, the crowd quieted a little, which allowed me to notice Steph yelling in from cageside. Again, I don't think that generally does much good, but I've often found the general rules don't apply to Danni. She's been doing this a long time, and I've noticed she has a way of absorbing things indirectly. I've also noticed that she and Steph enjoy a weird, almost telepathic connection. It's why they work so well together, both in and out of the cage. So I saw no sign Danni heard a word RSI's chief strategist was saying, but that didn't necessarily mean the message was not received.

Thirty seconds to go as Gercke restarted the action. At first, the fighters seemed content to ride out the round. Circling and pawing to little effect. Twenty seconds to go. No change. Fifteen seconds. Steph yelled something from outside, and Danni surged forward. Fox locked in her guard, wary of the way Steph had somehow activated Danni's offense. Was it some sort of plan? A shrewd tactic meant to exploit some sort of weakness? But it turned out there was no magic strategy afoot. Danni was simply pressing the action and looking for openings... and she found plenty. Fox held her guard high, so Danni went low - burying the left

hand in Megan's gut. Fox's guard came down, and Danni took advantage of the opening it left behind. A solid, straight right hand connected with Megan's jaw. Fox was forced to retreat. Danni went right with her as the clacker sounded the ten second warning. Her jab found it's mark. Megan's guard came up and Danni put the right hand downstairs - a lunging punch that landed nearly dead on Megan's belly button. The guard came down and another left hit Fox in the face. The withering assault caused Megan to lose track of where she was in the cage, and the fence came up sooner than she expected. Five seconds to go. Danni turned the offense all the way up. Punch after punch tested Megan's defense. Most found their way through. Another strong right buckled Fox's knees, but the bell sounded and saved her from further damage.

A lost opportunity? It was hard to say no. If Danni had launched her attack earlier, Megan Fox would probably be laying on the canvas right now.

So what the hell had happened?

Oh it was just Steph... doing her thing.

While Danni had been shocking the shit out of me with her clandestine ground skills, there was nothing secretive or surprising about her striking game. She was one of the best, without exception. Couple it with her masterful defense, and she can stand and trade with anyone. But Megan's game doesn't play into that sort of thing. She likes to grab and grapple, and she wouldn't think twice about latching on to an arm or leg that was left exposed too long. So far, Danni had been excellent about protecting herself. Her strikes had been well-targeted and well-placed, and she'd been religious about recovering to guard quickly. But two minutes of grinding it out on the mat takes a lot out of you. When you're tired, you make mistakes.

What's all that got to do with the wasted fifteen seconds? Well, I had no doubt now that Danni had gotten Steph's initial message. She was telling her to wait. Making a mistake with thirty seconds to go would give Fox a lot of time to take advantage and break off an arm. Steph wanted to let more time bleed off. Then she turned Danni loose at the fifteen second mark, when there was less chance a mistake would be fatal. Why not just let the round run out and avoid the risk altogether? Because Steph is careful but not overprotective. A tired Danni is not a helpless Danni, and Fox was pretty worn out, too. There was opportunity there. Megan had totally controlled two thirds of the frame as she did her thing on the ground. Danni's bold and emphatic escape technique had certainly made an impression on the judges, but was it enough to steal the round away? It didn't matter now. The flurry at the end had sealed the deal, and Danni was now up two points with one round to go. It had been a risk worth taking.

The break brought a flurry of activity to the RSI corner. Damage-wise, Danni was still largely unmarked, so Marcy went to work on conditioning. Using her abilities to help her fighter get the most out of the one minute rest period. Steph was patiently reviewing strategy for the last round, with Danni nodding along. Confidence, intelligence and harmony radiated from the group. Victory was in their grasp, and they weren't going to let it get away.

On the other side of the cage, a little panic had started to edge in. The fight was getting away from them, and Megan had taken some heavy hits. Her corner was working hard to control the swelling - which I had no doubt they'd do - but the damage had still taken it's toll. Real fighting is not like a video game. There is

no health bar to deplete. But there is something of a correlation. No matter how tough a fighter is, each one has her limit. On top of that, taking damage slows you down and steals your power, making it that much more difficult to come back. And being behind at this point meant Fox was going to have to come all the way back. Winning the final round wasn't likely to get her the victory. She needed the finish. Everyone in the arena knew she could do it, but she would have to take chances to make it happen.

Danni, meanwhile, was able to take the conservative approach. Keeping Fox at bay was all she needed to do to secure herself a spot in the final, and everyone knows that getting to Danni becomes almost impossible once she's free to go defensive.

Fox gave it everything she had and then some, but Danni made her life absolutely miserable. It started with a little game of chess. Megan trying to outmaneuver Danni and catch her against the fence. She never got close. Danni used the jab to maintain space and her movement never ceased. Jab-circle-jab-circle. It was monotonous and frustrating and it was eating away at the clock. Megan's corner was shouting... both to encourage and to inspire. She would have to do more, and she would have to do it now.

Fox tried harder... using her own jab to limit Danni's movement and try to get her to engage. It worked, to some degree. Danni wasn't able to circle out as easily, and Megan was able to get lined up and shoot in for a takedown. No luck. Danni saw it coming a mile away and defended it perfectly... executing a series of steps nearly simultaneously. She used her head and hands to knock Fox off line, just as Dove had done against Keri Russell. She punched her hips back - throwing her legs back and out. Getting them out of reach and setting a nice, wide base so Fox couldn't topple her over. Then she just settled in for the ride. Fox pushed and surged, but Danni kept using those hands to turn the forward momentum sideways. Megan was forced to her left, and Danni circled the same way. The two did almost a complete turn with Fox pushing and Danni basically riding over top of her. Megan finally lost her momentum and tried to retreat, and Danni whacked her in the mouth with a short right hand. A little parting gift to remember their dance.

One minute gone. Megan was running out of time. She tried the shoot twice more, and paid the price each time.

Another thirty seconds gone. Desperation set in. The circuitous route wasn't working because Danni refused to cooperate. Megan needed a direct approach... and she chose to do the unthinkable.

She picked a spot to make her stand, and willingly traded punches with her opponent.

It was a stunning decision, and Megan actually landed a few solid shots before Danni understood what was happening. After that... it was an ugly scene. Megan punching and mostly missing. Danni guarding and finding huge holes to work with. Pounding heavy shots into Fox's face and body from all angles. Blood started to flow... all of it coming from Megan. She was playing a game she could not win, but she refused to surrender. Twice, the heavy onslaught forced her to retreat, but Fox would barely stop for a breather before wading back in. It was like some sort of last ditch suicide mission.

But no... not quite. It seemed Megan still had one last trick up her sleeve. As she surged in again, she threw her guard up high and came in under it. The move worked. She took another heavy round of abuse, but she got inside. She got her arms around Danni's waist, then slid down and grabbed her left leg. Single leg

takedown. It was sloppy, but maybe that was the point. It was so ugly, it was almost unrecognizable, and Danni hadn't seen it coming. Megan stood up and ripped the leg off the mat. Danni went down flat on her back.

Fox raced forward in a frenzied, adrenaline-fueled rush. Her fans went crazy.

Holy shit... she was going to do it.

Nope. No she wasn't.

Danni got her legs up to guard... then even further. Drawing them up to her chest. Megan saw it too late. She was committed... already lunging onto her fallen opponent. Danni kicked out and drove the flats of her feet into Megan's chest, and - for just a second or so - Megan Fox achieved flight.

She landed just over three feet away, and rolled directly to her feet. It had been a tremendous kick and it had to have hurt like hell, but she couldn't worry about that. She had to get back to Danni. She couldn't let her stand up.

Too late. Danni was up and ready by the time Fox turned around.

Twenty seconds remaining. Would Megan give it another go?

She did... and she shouldn't have.

Twenty seconds was not a lot of time for a submission fighter to work, so Megan played no games. She rushed straight in. Danni stood with her guard up... like a matador facing down a charging bull. Would Fox go low and try for another takedown, or would she try something high risk? Along with a complete set of locks and traditional submissions, Fox had all kinds of crazy flying armbars and such in her arsenal. Would she break out one of those?

Megan went low. It was a sound decision. She'd put Danni on the canvas three times by going after her legs, and she had every reason to believe it would work again. If Danni blocked it she blocked it. It was worth a try.

Danni didn't block it, but I'll bet Megan wishes she had.

I don't know what her thought process was. Maybe she was tired of playing Fox's game. Maybe she didn't want to chance messing with her crafty opponent anymore. Or maybe she saw Megan go low and instinct took over from there. Whatever the reason, Danni didn't bother with hand-checking or sprawling or setting a base. Instead she took a big step forward... and drove her knee straight into Megan's oncoming face.

The sound that echoed through the arena was like a wooden bat hitting a baseball. Megan's body didn't even spasm. She just fell flat on the canvas and did not move.

There was no chance nothing was broken. No chance whatsoever.

Gercke quickly signaled the end of the fight, and Danni's fans let out a roar. The uncommitted members of the crowd gleefully joined in... because who doesn't love a good knockout?

The cage door opened and the medical staff charged in, with Megan's team right behind them. Our group filed in last, steering well clear of the activity surrounding Fox. Steph, Amanda, Marcy... all veteran professionals. No one needed to be reminded to hold off on the celebration. Not after a brutal finish like that. They quietly made their way to Danni, who was squatted down on her haunches on the far side of the cage. There was a quick round of muted congratulations for a fight well-fought and a victory well-earned. Danni nodded her thanks, and even let a little smile slip onto her face. She was concerned for her opponent, but she was by no means distraught. Though she was one of the most caring people I know, she was also a fighter. Moments like this are part of the deal. Fox had made the decision to throw caution to the wind and go for broke. Danni had done what she needed to do to stop her. That's the way it goes.

Still... Megan was down for a very long time. Long enough to put that awful feeling in the pit of your stomach. Even when she did finally come around, she was not in great shape. After a lengthy checkout, the medical staff eventually got her on her feet. Danni stood, but stayed out of the way. Waiting to see how things were going to go. If maybe they wanted to just get Fox out of there. In the end, it was Megan herself who made the decision. She noticed Danni waiting and gestured the others aside. The two clasped hands and shared a few words. I never know what Danni says in these moments. I only know there always seems to be a ridiculous amount of warmth on display between people who were trying to kill each other only moments ago. But that's Danni for you. She respects her opponents, and they, in turn, show tremendous respect for her.

Well... most of them, anyway.

After the little moment, the medics asserted their authority and escorted Megan to one of the treatment rooms. That gave Danni the chance to enjoy her win a bit more. Or, more correctly, it gave the crowd the chance to show their appreciation for the fantastic performance she'd put on. Danni acknowledged them with her typical humility. A smile here. A little wave there. Exactly the response her fans expect.

For the record, I checked in with Megan's stable owner later, and the report was about what I figured. She was being treated for a possible concussion, though early results were reasonably good. Of greater concern was the broken orbital bone around her left eye. The result of that fight ending collision between her face and Danni's knee. It was a bad injury that would keep her out of action for quite a while, but it was also much more common than most people think. Many RSI fighters had dealt with it, and I had no doubt Megan would be back and hungry for more as soon as possible.

With that concern settled, my thoughts turned to Danni. And oh, what wonderful thoughts they were...

There was no doubting it now. No reason to question or qualify. Months ago, I had set out a goal. I wanted Danni to be the best she'd ever been, and now I had proof that she was. Her win over Julie Benz had been an early sign. Not just that she'd won, but the commanding way in which she'd done it. Her march through the early rounds here had only added to the growing feeling. But this win over Fox had sealed it for me.

Danni was as good as I'd ever seen her at the things she does well. Solid defense. Powerful, precise striking. Keen ring awareness. She had it all going for her. But tonight she had shown me something I hadn't been looking for. She'd shown just how much she'd improved at the things most saw as her weaknesses. Not only that, she'd gained a confidence in those areas she never had in the past. I mean, going after Megan Fox on the canvas? Not once, but TWICE? Where in the holy hell had that come from?

I already knew the answer. A few months ago, Steph had said there's something about me that brought the best out of Danni, and now it was clear that her teammates were doing that too. Not only for her, but also for each other.

Early in our existence, RSI had discovered a secret formula for success. Danni, Steph, myself... it was so secret, even we didn't quite understand it. We only knew it was working. We were winning, so we were obviously doing the right thing.

Now we knew that thinking was too narrow. Success made us conservative, and we had closed ourselves off to the possibility that we could be even better. Danni's struggles had changed all that. The stable had come together in a whole new way. Old bonds were strengthened. New ones were formed. The end result? We were better than ever, and we were proving it here at this tournament. Four final matchups were set, and every one of them featured one of our fighters. My hope from earlier had already been accomplished with four title bouts still to be determined. And we had at least one fighter vying for a spot in each of those, as well.

There was no doubt about it. This was shaping up to be a historic event for RSI.

How this training renaissance came to be depended on how you chose to look at it. My opinion was that - even in her lowest moment - Danni had made the whole group better. That everything she had given these women over the years had inspired them to give back to her now. To the point where they had gone ahead and invented a whole new approach just to make it happen.

Of course, if I said that to her, she would no doubt tell me to go jump in a lake. She would say the credit should go to the the others. That this new way of doing things had come exclusively from them.

She would be right, but that didn't make me wrong.

As the festivities in the cage concluded, I made my way down to the RSI locker room. Danni was in a training room, with Trish and Marcy just finishing up their exam.

"What's the verdict?" I smiled at them.

"She's fine," Trish said evenly.

Marcy took it a step further.

"She could go another three rounds right now, if we let her."

"Ohhh... no thank you," Danni protested. "I'm good."

"Probably wouldn't be too bad," I said. "Megan wouldn't be much competition for you, in her current state."

I fully expected Danni to chastise me for making light of Fox's condition, but Trish cut in first.

"Wasn't much competition for you before," she said.

"TRISH!" I said in mild shock.

Trish's level of fanaticism regarding these fights was severely limited. If our fighters came out whole and healthy... that she was a fan of. Anything less got a big thumbs down. Overall, I don't think she enjoys the sport very much. In fact, I think she believes the rest of us must be slightly brain dead to abuse our bodies the way we do. So, to hear her voice a rooting interest was more than a little surprising.

"I seen what I seen," she said with a shrug. Then she turned and left before I could ask any questions, with Marcy right behind her.

I turned back to Danni.

"You're making a fight fan out of Trish."

"I highly doubt that," she replied.

Despite what we'd heard, I doubted it myself. So, I let it go.

"So," I said after a brief lull, "when did you become a ground specialist?"

"I'm not. I was just going with the flow."

"Uh, huh... that the way Steph wanted you to flow?"

"She was pretty happy with the final outcome."

"Mmm," was the snappiest come back I had for that one. After all, MMA is the ultimate form of results-based accountability. *Win any way you can*, is the standard operating procedure once the cage door closes. Do better than your opponent, and you'll come out the winner. Do worse, and you're likely to end up lying on the canvas with your face broken.

I would never know just how much of what happened against Fox had been pre-planned, Steph-approved strategy and how much had been Danni improvising. I only knew the victory had been thorough and complete. And that would definitely be Steph-approved.

No sooner had I said Steph's name when the door opened and there she was... wearing the same flat expression she'd shown when she delivered the news about Emma facing Nadine Coyle. I knew right away she had come to give a similar report about Danni's final opponent, but I couldn't immediately fill in the blank. Throughout the tournament, my focus had been squarely on Danni when the welterweights were in action... to the point that I'd paid zero attention to the other half of the bracket. I didn't even know for certain who the possibilities were.

One thing was for sure... it was one of the bigs. Steph's look made that clear.

I ran through a mental catalog of the top welterweights.

Candice Swanepoel? Eliminated. Gabriela Cilmi? Out. Catrinel Menghia, Jennifer Connelly, Fox... all gone.

So who could...

"It's Cole," I breathed as the obvious answer suddenly dawned on me.

Steph responded with a single nod.

I turned to Danni, who shrugged as if to say, *makes no difference to me*.

And maybe, to some degree, that made sense. After all, every one of those women I listed would have been a serious threat to her title hopes. Swanepoel and Cilmi in particular have bested her on a number of occasions. So, while Cole was extremely dangerous, she was no more or less so than the others.

But, of course, it did make a difference.

In my mind, this tournament was to be a showcase. A five part series of increasingly emphatic declarations that Danni was back and better than ever. With the win over Fox, the first four steps had been completed in almost dreamlike fashion. She'd been sensational in ways even I couldn't have expected. Just one more win, and then it would be back to the gym... with a new belt in her hand, that confident glint in her eye and a whole stable full of women who would not rest until she had her revenge on Cheryl Cole.

Only now, here was Cole... six months too soon.

Danni's shrug... well, with her, who knows what it meant? Maybe it meant she felt ready right now. Maybe it meant she was silently worrying about what this might mean for her future.

Maybe it meant she was distracted because that lowlight film from last time was playing through her head again.

Regardless, there was one thing I knew for certain. I wasn't ready for this rematch to happen. Not now. Not yet.